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Passage 146. The river had been rising for three days, and by the morning of the fourth the lower fields were under water. Nobody in the valley was surprised, because the same thing happened every spring, but this year the water came faster than anyone remembered and it did not stop at the old stone wall.

Passage 147. Thomas walked along the top of the wall with his hands in his pockets, counting the fence posts that still showed above the flood. There were eleven of them, and then there was nothing but brown water all the way to the line of trees on the far side.

Passage 148. His mother called him in for breakfast. She had been up since before dawn moving the hens to the barn, and she was not in the mood for a boy who stood about looking at things that could not be helped.

Passage 149. After breakfast the rain stopped. The clouds did not clear, but they lifted a little, and the light that came through them was grey and even and made the whole valley look like an old photograph of itself.

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